Current-State Process Map / Process Trace

IIIT Hyderabad Breakfast Mess System

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Overview

The Stakeholder Map says who is involved. This trace says what actually happens, step by step, workarounds included. It follows one breakfast from the student's registration through the operator's planning and cooking to the counter, the close, and what happens to the food nobody eats.

Three timescales are kept apart. Registration is locked about four days ahead, and because every student is registered automatically it works as a standing month-long default, not a choice. Cooked quantity is set the day before: as a share of registrations at Kadamba, from the mess's own past records at Yuktāhār, and at Bakul as an item-dependent share the manager adjusts weekly from past attendance. The decision to eat is made on the morning itself, and the operator responds live at the counter. At Yuktāhār it also re-forecasts the rest of the meal from the first half hour, so the morning holds an operator forecast as well as a reaction.

(Revised: the first version covered only the student half and stopped at the kitchen door, because no source then showed how a registration became a cooked quantity.) Operator interviews at three messes, one mess's photographed planning and attendance registers, a month of timestamped Kadamba scans, a walkthrough of the Kadamba kitchen and the team's first-hand account of two visits now make the operator half visible. The two best-evidenced operators run on different logics, so the trace follows each end to end. Bakul, cooked off site, is traced on its manager's account alone, since no Bakul records exist. What stays unseen is narrow and listed at the end.

Conduct Interviews and Observations

Source	Represents	Reveals	Cannot establish
Original respondent (2026-09-03)	One habitual skipper, general system informant	System mechanics (registration, billing, QR, Mess Cell, governance) and one person's skip reasons	Whether the reasons generalise

Source	Represents	Reveals	Cannot establish
Portal screenshots and the printed CDS Student Handbook	The registration and billing platform and its published rules	Prices, capacities, registration counts, Skip Meal versus Cancel, the four-day registration and cancellation deadline, automatic allocation of a vegetarian meal	Attendance, since registration is not attendance
Five student interviews (2026-09-06)	Two daily eaters, three skippers	Decision sequences, queue and crowding, item run-outs, registration habits, Mess Cell use, timing preferences, self-estimated spend on unused meals	Whether six respondents represent the population
CFS Chair interview and Kadamba kitchen walkthrough (2026-09-13)	The dining-services side and one kitchen's layout	Governance and feedback triage, the entry cut-off and refill window, equipment, one person running all inventory on first-in-first-out and first-expiry-first-out	Day-to-day quantity decisions
Yuktāhār walkthrough with 26 photographed registers (2026-09-26)	The site head of ABC Hospitality Services walking through every register	The planning system: twice-daily meeting, Wastage Book, weekday attendance register, grocery and stock books, reuse, staff routines	Other messes; how typical one well-documented operator is
Kadamba manager interview (September 2026)	The mess manager of Prism	Waste handling, exceptions (scanner failure, gas shortage, broken equipment), complaint routing	Figures not covered by the team account; the audio is noisy
Team field account of the Kadamba and Yuktāhār visits (2026-09-27)	A team member present at both operator conversations, and a Kadamba student	The Kadamba command chain, quantity rule, gram standards, food-safety sequence, extra diners, timing and procurement; the Yuktāhār books, forecasting steps, organisation and culture; auto-registration from the student side	A verbatim operator transcript; the base of Kadamba's waste figure
Bakul manager and staff (September 2026), synthesised by a team member who understood the conversation	The operator of Bakul, cooked at Hafizpet	Tender and monthly payment, the weekly-adjusted first batch and its floor, early preparation, transport and hot holding, 30-minute checks and phone top-up, the late reserve, pairing views, the complaint route	Any Bakul record; the top-up lead time; whether Palash is served the same way
Kadamba breakfast records, April 2026	32,162 registrations and 11,941 timestamped scans from dining services	Attendance by day, weekday and veg or non-veg; the arrival curve minute by minute; when service really ends	Which individuals skip; lunch and dinner; quantities cooked or wasted
Power-Interest/Leverage analysis	Governance structure	Formal and informal power, precedent, the Parliament's Mess Secretary role	Kitchen operations

System visibility. Everything from a student's own decision through billing, and now everything from registration reaching the kitchen through cooking, service and disposal, is visible for two messes. Confidence differs. The Yuktāhār account is confirmed where it rests on the registers and single-sourced where it rests on the operator's explanation. (Revised: the Kadamba rule, gram standards, safety sequence and timing were first held as a noisy recording with doubtful numbers. A team member heard the same conversation directly, so they are now the operator's single-sourced statements with the figures no longer in doubt. The Bakul account was likewise first held as noisy audio from an unnamed mess, and is now the manager's single-sourced statements, still his own estimates with no records.) The Kadamba attendance figures are confirmed from records.

Observation. A live breakfast service has not been watched from start to finish. The 11,941 Kadamba scans answer what that observation was meant to capture, the shape and timing of the crowd, better than one morning of counting could. The team saw the wrapped display plate at Kadamba's entrance and the Yuktāhār books themselves. Waste disposal after close still needs direct observation.

Trace Decisions and Interactions

Registration is locked about four days ahead. The CDS handbook requires registration and cancellation at least four days in advance, and Kadamba's manager calls it ”weekly compulsory.” Students say they register ”for a month,” three of six explicitly. Both hold: the portal locks on a four-day weekly rhythm and students set a standing booking once. A team member's own experience as a Kadamba student adds that registration is automatic and mandatory, off campus and over holidays, and that the only exit is five cancellations per meal type per month made four days

ahead: ”we don't have any opportunity to nullify it.” The booking is a default. Kadamba's April records confirm the result: registrations flat at about 1,070 a day on every weekday including Sunday (range 928 to 1,123) while turnout runs from 42.1% on Tuesdays to 27.3% on Sundays.

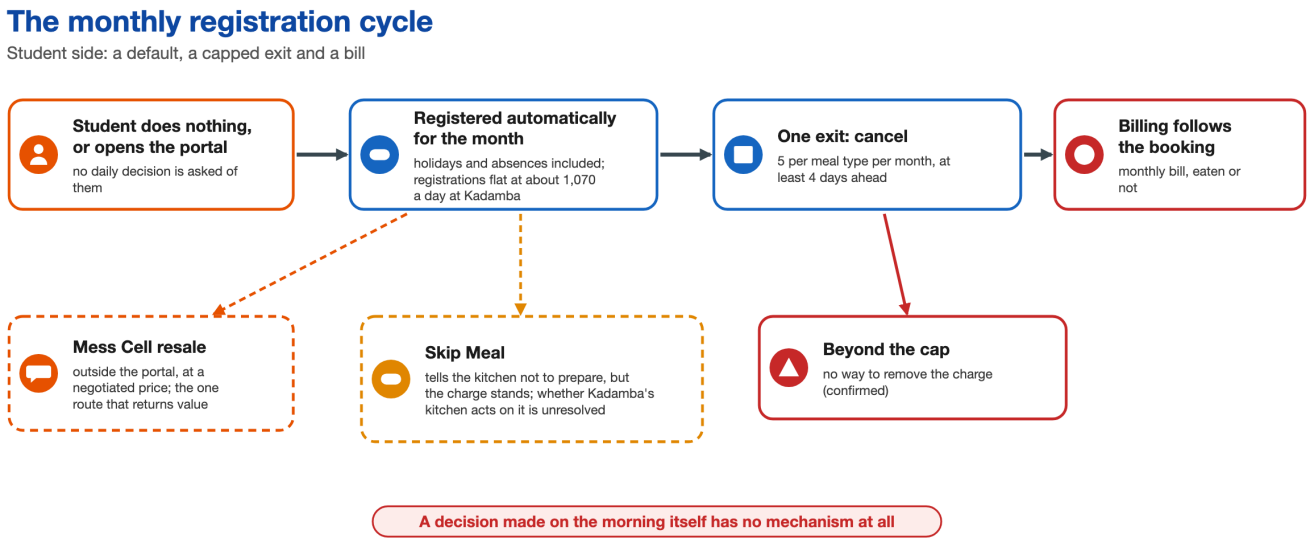


Figure 1. *The monthly registration cycle, from the automatic default to the bill.*

The daily cycle is where the go-or-skip decision happens. It is evidenced across all six student respondents and now measured at record level.

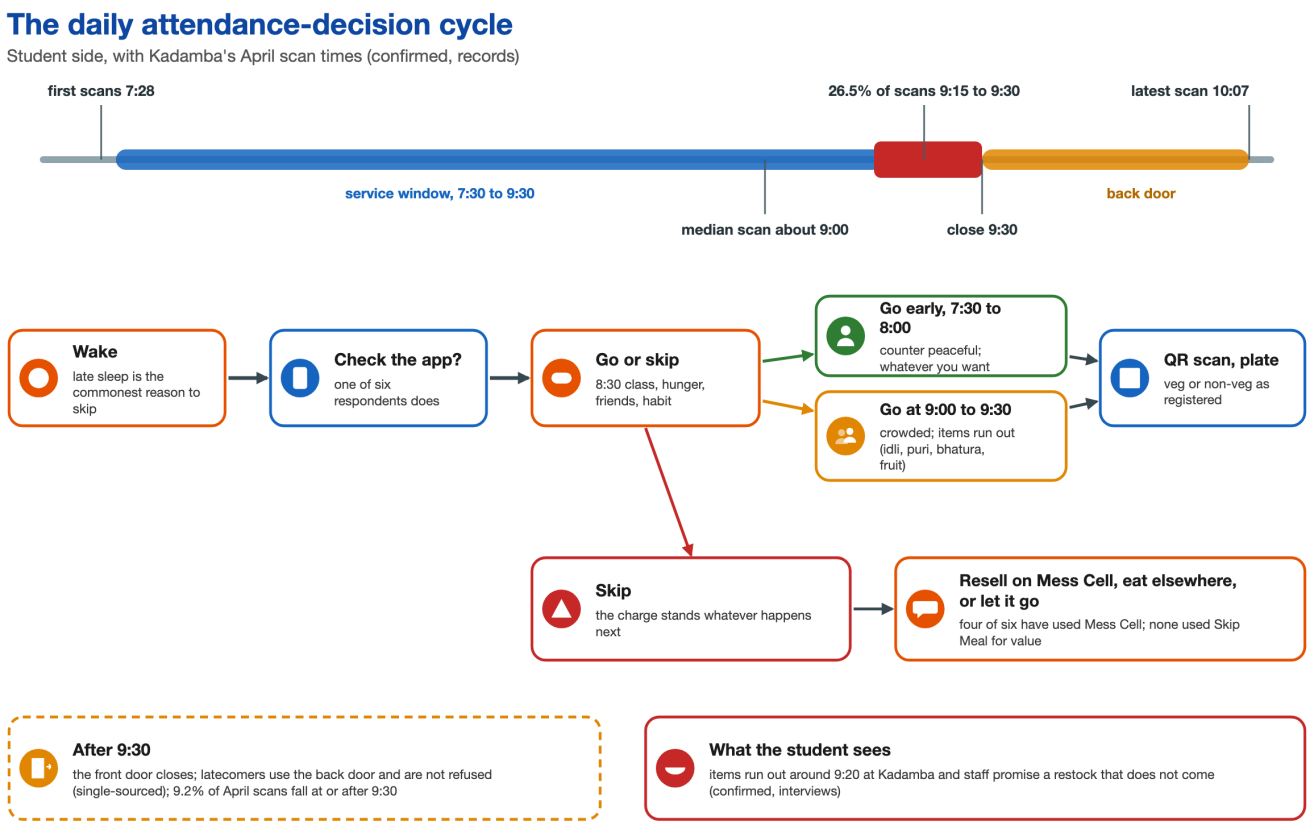


Figure 2. The daily attendance-decision cycle on the student side.

Decision points, supported by evidence only

Decision points: students

Decision	Who	When	Constraint	Options observed
Register or not	Student	At least four days ahead; in practice once for the month	Registration is automatic and mandatory, holidays included; popular messes fill; a student who does not register is allocated a vegetarian meal	All six register in advance, none day by day
Which mess	Student	At registration	Capacity, competition for popular messes	Kadamba chosen by four of six; Bakul mentioned once
Go or skip, that morning	Student	On waking	8:30 class and attendance policy (named by one respondent)	Go, skip, go later. The central real decision, evidenced across all six and confirmed by records: 37.1% of Kadamba breakfast registrations used in April, lowest on Sundays (27.3%); Yuktāhār September breakfast 17.7 to 40.2%, Sundays among the lowest. No Bakul records; its manager estimates at most about 60%, fewer at weekends (single-sourced)
Check the app first	Student	Before or instead of deciding	A crowd-check and menu view exist	One of six checks; the rest ignore it
Wait for or wake friends	Student	On waking	The friend's own wake state	Wakes them and goes regardless (two of six); not a factor (three); positive but non-determining (one)

Decision	Who	When	Constraint	Options observed
When to arrive	Student	That morning	9:30 entry cut-off	Skewed late. The median April scan fell between 8:51 and 9:11 by weekday, about half of scans came after 9:00 and 26.5% in the last quarter hour. Kadamba's rule of thumb is about 100 early, 100 in the middle and 150 in the last ten minutes: ”for any meal the highest flow is in the last 10 minutes.” Bakul's manager puts his main rush at 8:00 to 8:30, with 10 to 15 in the last ten minutes (single-sourced; no Bakul scans)
Cancel a registration	Student	At least four days ahead	Cap of five per meal type per month (confirmed)	Used by most at least occasionally; one does not, because they forget
Use Skip Meal	Student	Same day or ahead	Returns no money	Never used by any of the six who addressed it
Resell or buy via Mess Cell	Student	When a registration will go unused	Informal, no guaranteed buyer	Used by four of six; a bystander for one; not for breakfast for another
Eat as a walk-in	Student	Same day, unregistered	Price markup	Snacks only (one); breakfast (one); never (three). Yuktāhār's register counts Jain, unregistered, paying and faculty or staff diners separately; at breakfast the extras are at most about a dozen a day
Enter after the close	Student	After 9:30	The front door closes at 9:30	At Kadamba latecomers use the back door and staff do not refuse them

A hypothesis this data disconfirms. Early drafts treated social company as a meaningful driver of attendance. Six respondents tell a weaker story: peer presence is at most a motivational add-on, never the deciding factor. Nobody describes skipping because a friend skipped, or attending only because one did.

Decision points: operators

The three operators forecast in three ways. Kadamba cooks a fixed share of registrations and tops up reactively, with no learning record beyond per-dish gram standards. Yuktāhār learns from its own books, looking up the matching past week before service and re-projecting from the first half hour during it. Bakul sits between. (Revised: an earlier reading, from a noisy recording that gave only the ratio, had Bakul resembling Kadamba.) Its manager varies the share by item and adjusts it weekly from past attendance by judgement, never below a floor he keeps against shortage. Whether any history is written down is unknown.

Kadamba (run by Prism)

Decision	Who	When	Inputs and constraint	Confidence
Set the first batch	Prism kitchen management	The day before, from the weekly menu	About 70% of registrations, veg and non-veg planned separately; a per-person gram standard for every dish (idli 4 a head from about 120 g of batter, sambar 100 g, poha and pulao their own). Biryani lunch is the exception, at 100%	Single-sourced (operator, heard first-hand)
Cook for people outside the registration	Prism kitchen	Same planning step	About 30 extra portions for 30 to 50 outside people, such as night-shift security; about half of Kadamba's staff also eat from the same food	Single-sourced
Order raw material	Prism	In three tiers	Dry goods (rice, groundnut, masala, ghee, podi) a week ahead; perishables (milk, fruit, meat, eggs, most vegetables) the day before; some vegetables two to three days ahead	Single-sourced
Hold raw stock for a top-up	Kadamba kitchen	Morning	The uncooked remainder can be cooked in 10 to 15 minutes on request	Single-sourced
Watch the counter and call a top-up	The supervisor	Throughout service	Item levels at each time, registrations and turnout so far; the supervisor tells the kitchen how much more to cook. Items that ”float” above the gram standard are bonda, puri, vada and idli	Single-sourced

Decision	Who	When	Inputs and constraint	Confidence
Serve latecomers	Floor staff	After the 9:30 close	Latecomers enter by the back door and the mess ”can't say no to them”; on one biryani day the door was reopened for 5 to 10 minutes	Back door single-sourced; reopening single-sourced from noisy audio; breakfast application supported by scans after 9:30 on every April day
Dispose of leftovers	Kitchen	After close	Part is eaten by outside diners and staff; the rest goes to a bin collected by a garbage contractor	Single-sourced
Record the outcome	Kadamba kitchen	Daily and weekly	About 5 to 10% daily wastage on an unstated base, hard to square with a 70% batch against 37.1% turnout (see Key Findings); QC weekly. Per-item weighing is not established	Single-sourced

Yuktāhār (run by ABC Hospitality Services)

Decision	Who	When	Inputs and constraint	Confidence
Set tomorrow's breakfast and lunch quantities	Storekeeper, coordinator and kitchen staff in the first-half daily meeting; a second meeting sets snacks and dinner	The day before	Portal registrations as regular plus Jain plus cash meals; the Wastage Book page for the matching past week (the menu repeats on a two-week cycle: weeks 1 and 3 identical, weeks 2 and 4 identical) with its run-out times and quantities; the month's pattern; the weekday attendance register; holidays, exams and events, only if someone raises them (”We don't come to know until we sit in the meeting”). No fixed ratio; the site head believes breakfast runs at about 50%	Registers confirmed; forecasting steps single-sourced
Raise exceptions and discrepancies	Everyone, in the same meetings	Twice a day	The day's positives, negatives and discrepancies; impurities found in cleaning; store and cooked-quantity mismatches; leave requests (there is no formal policy and colleagues absorb the load)	Single-sourced
Issue raw material per meal	Storekeeper, cross-checked by the cross-verifier	Written at the planning meeting; issued the evening before or that morning	The per-dish ingredient list in kilograms from the store book; the Grocery Book with breakfast, lunch, snacks and dinner columns and a running balance	Confirmed from photographed registers
Clean and sort grain; judge the supplier	Store function	After issue	Raw material comes from many local shops and godowns, so stones are expected. An expected grams-of-impurity norm per item applies; exceeding it means a complaint or a new supplier, raised in the meeting	Practice confirmed; norm single-sourced
Cook in one batch or two	Kitchen	5:30 to 7:30	Most items in one batch; only items that dry out, such as poha, in two. The site head argues against general batching because ”student fluctuation is very high”	Confirmed
Re-project the rest of the meal	Coordinator and kitchen	First half hour of service	Turnout in the first half hour is a sample for the rest, driving top-up cooking	Single-sourced; breakfast use candidate
Monitor the counter	Kitchen	Every 30 minutes from about 45 minutes before close (about 8:45)	Food left against expected arrivals; a second roti counter opens at peak (handmade, no oil)	Checks confirmed; roti counters confirmed, meal not specified
Re-cook or not	Kitchen	When an item runs out	Stated for lunch: ”If it runs out at 1:30 we re-cook; if at 2:20 we don't.” The Wastage Book has run-out and re-cook columns. The same cut-off at breakfast is a candidate	Rule confirmed; breakfast candidate

Decision	Who	When	Inputs and constraint	Confidence
Reuse leftovers	Kitchen	After close	Idli becomes idli upma or idli poha for lunch; dosa batter goes back to the fridge; surplus milk is set as curd; paneer is made in-house	Confirmed
Record the outcome	The mess in-charge, cross-checked by peers	After each meal	The Wastage Book, where daily meal wastage is student plate waste in the bins plus leftover food	Confirmed

Bakul (Vijayalakshmi Caterers, cooked at Hafizpet). Every row is the manager's own account. No Bakul record of any kind has been seen, so every number is his statement or estimate.

Decision	Who	When	Inputs and constraint	Confidence
Set the first batch	The Bakul manager	Reviewed week by week	About 70 to 80% of registrations, by item, from attendance history by day (his example: if Mondays have run near 70%, cook about 80% of Monday's registrations; that 70% sits above his own breakfast estimate of at most about 60%, so it may not describe breakfast). (Revised: an earlier reading had a standing 70% raised to 80%. The two numbers describe variation by item and day, not change over time.)	Single-sourced; whether history is written down is open
Keep a shortage floor	The Bakul manager	Every day, visibly at weekends	His principle: ”there should not be a shortage of food, even if some wastage occurs.” Even on weekends, when breakfast attendance is ”very low,” he keeps food for about 70% of registrations	Single-sourced
Start labour-heavy items	Hafizpet kitchen	From about 3 AM	Items such as aloo paratha start around 3 AM to reach Bakul about 7, so some food is held for hours before it is eaten	Single-sourced
Transport and hold	Hafizpet, then the Bakul mess	Early morning	About 8 km, about 20 minutes early and 40 later; insulated boxes at about 60 to 72 °C, set in a hot-water holding setup. The heat is kept; steam softens hot parathas	Single-sourced
Check the counter	The Bakul manager	About every 30 minutes	Food remaining against registrations and demand still expected	Single-sourced
Call a top-up	The manager, by phone to Hafizpet	When food looks short	He gives an approximate quantity; the kitchen cooks and sends it. Lead time unstated. An earlier noisy reading said ”within 30 minutes,” possibly the check interval, and the drive alone is 20 to 40 minutes, so it is flagged, not relied on	Single-sourced; lead time open
Hold a late reserve	The manager	Around 9:20	He aims to still have food for about 50 at about 9:20, when 10 to 15 arrive in the last ten minutes. That it is held because a late top-up could not arrive is a candidate reading	Single-sourced; reason candidate
Dispose of leftovers	The Bakul mess	After close	Some leftovers go back to Hafizpet and the rest is thrown	Single-sourced (noisy audio)
Record the outcome	Not known	Not known	No attendance, consumption or waste record seen; his turnout figure (at most about 60%) is an estimate	Open

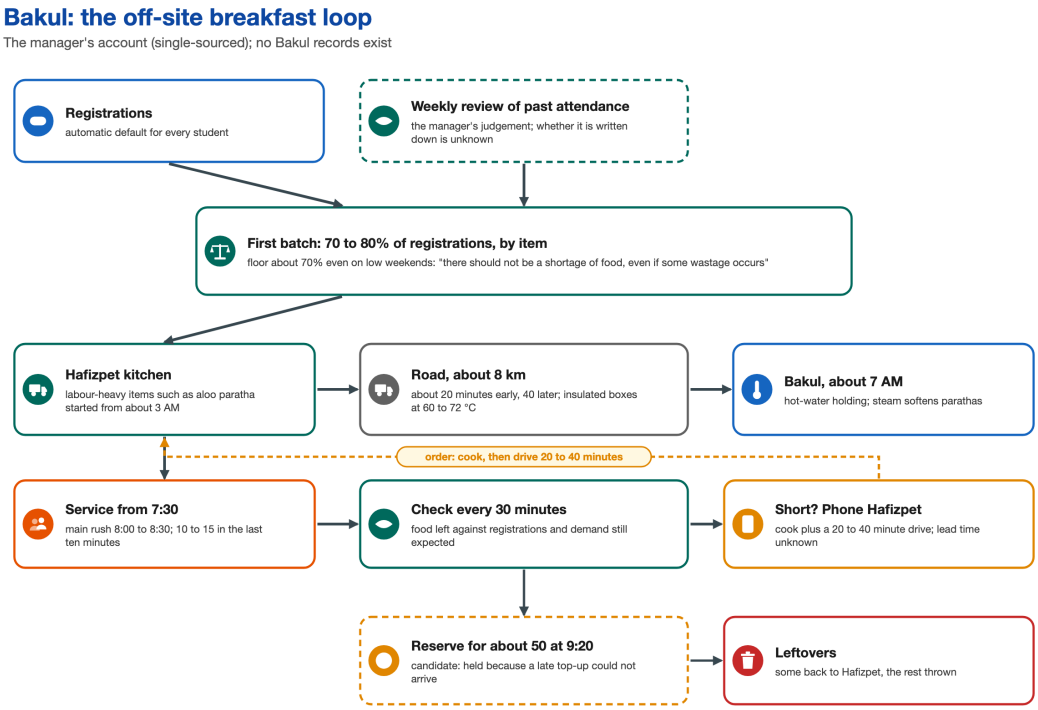


Figure 3. Bakul's breakfast loop from the weekly review to the late reserve.

Two readings follow from the manager's own numbers, both candidates. His first batch (70 to 80%) and weekend floor (about 70%) both exceed the highest turnout he expects (at most about 60%), so the batch exceeds turnout by design; if Bakul resembles the recorded halls at 28 to 37%, the gap is larger, and without records it cannot be sized. And the late reserve of about 50 is several times the 10 to 15 late arrivals he describes, the difference being insurance against a shortage a top-up from 8 km away could not fix in time.

Menu choice, all messes. The student committee chooses from an operator-supplied menu and the operator follows it. Operators see per-item waste (at Kadamba uttapam, set dosa and upma waste while puri, bonda, vada and idli move) and shift quantities between items, as Kadamba did in cutting ragi idli and increasing plain idli, but cannot change the menu. The Bakul manager asks for a say, and his objection is to pairings, not dishes: kachori belongs with chole, and he would serve Raj Kachori with aloo curry where the menu lists chana. He describes students choosing from balance, protein, carbohydrate and preference, and himself from traditional regional combinations, taste and what is eaten, with about 20 years in North Indian food. He also mentioned a protein target of about 30 to 40 g a meal, set by an unknown party, and cites pav bhaji as drawing more students and muesli and Chocos as eaten readily (single-sourced). This is the operator's view; whether Bakul residents share it is untested.

Yuktāhār: the book system as a process

Yuktāhār runs on paper books, each photographed by the team and explained by the operator. Everyone does every job, so ”storekeeper” is a function people rotate through, and each book is cross-checked by a peer.

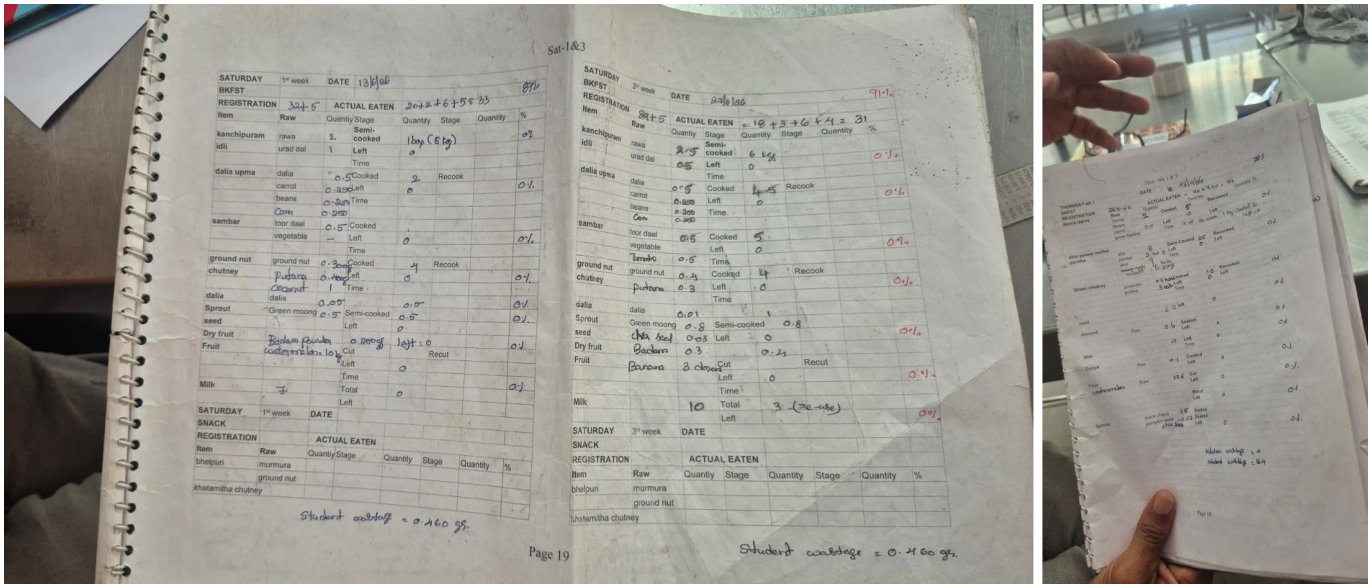


Figure 4. Yuktāhār's production and waste sheets for breakfast (a Saturday in June, a Thursday in September): raw issued, cooked, left, run-out time, re-cook and plate waste.

Book	Written by	When	Decision it feeds
Daily Meal Wastage Book: per meal and dish, raw issued, cooked, left, percentage, run-out time, re-cook quantity, registered (regular plus Jain), ate by category, and student bin waste plus leftover as the day's meal wastage	The mess in-charge, who also keeps the accounts	Every meal	The next matching-week quantity; the re-cook cut-off
Attendance register by weekday: registered against ate, every Sunday together, every Monday together	Coordinator	Every meal	Weekday turnout expectation
Wastage board	Coordinator	Daily	A target to push the waste share down
Grocery Book: issue per item per meal, day total, running balance; the header carries the day's registrations (18 September: breakfast 265+14, lunch 338+15, snacks 7+0, dinner 237+14)	Storekeeper, cross-checked by the cross-verifier	At the planning meeting for the next day	What the store pulls and cleans
Store and ingredient book: per-dish ingredient lists in kilograms	Storekeeper	Before each issue	The issue list
Stock register: one page per article, receipts in red	Store	Daily	Purchasing and the physical stock check
Vegetable book and vegetable indent: opening, received, used, balance; ordered against received, with remarks such as ”3 spoiled” or ”only 2 boxes”	The mess in-charge or the cross-verifier	Vegetables arrive two to three times a week	Vegetable orders; spoilage
Milk, fruit, gas, electricity and water register	Project team	Daily	Curd and paneer planning; machine run times (a Wednesday electricity spike comes from grinding idli batter)
Fridge temperature log and cleaning checklist	Hygiene team; the cross-verifier signs	Temperature three times a day; cleaning daily	Hygiene compliance

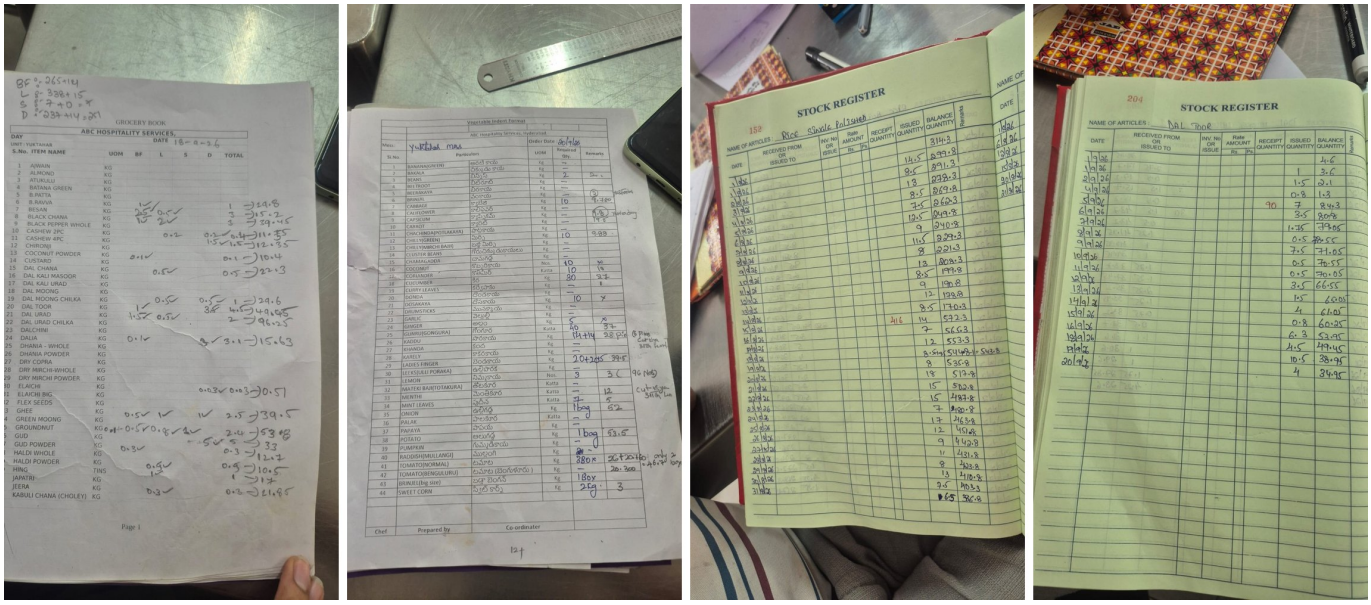


Figure 5. *The issue and stock books: Grocery Book page 1, the vegetable indent, and two stock register pages.*

One rule holds the books together: what the store book says was issued must match what the physical book says was cooked, and any mismatch is raised in the daily meeting. It held on the one day checked, 18 September, when 4.5 kg of toor dal issued and a 49.45 kg balance appear identically in the Grocery Book and the stock register (confirmed).

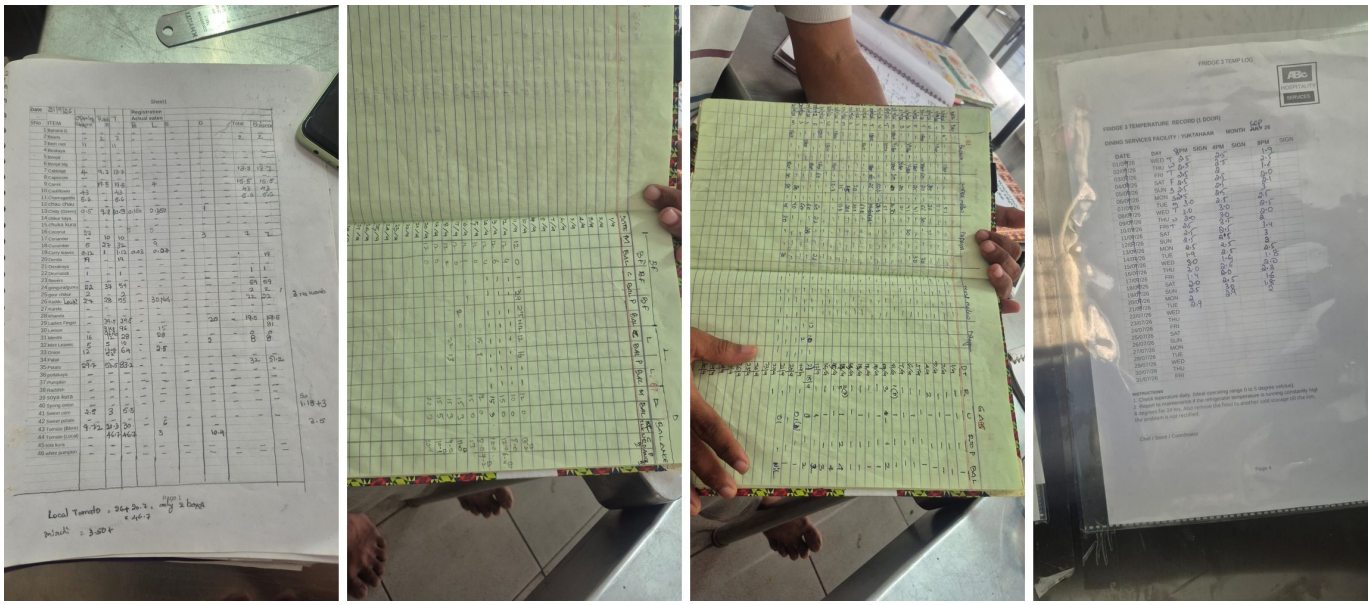


Figure 6. *The daily logs: vegetable stock, the milk and curd register, the fruit and gas register, and the Fridge 3 temperature record.*

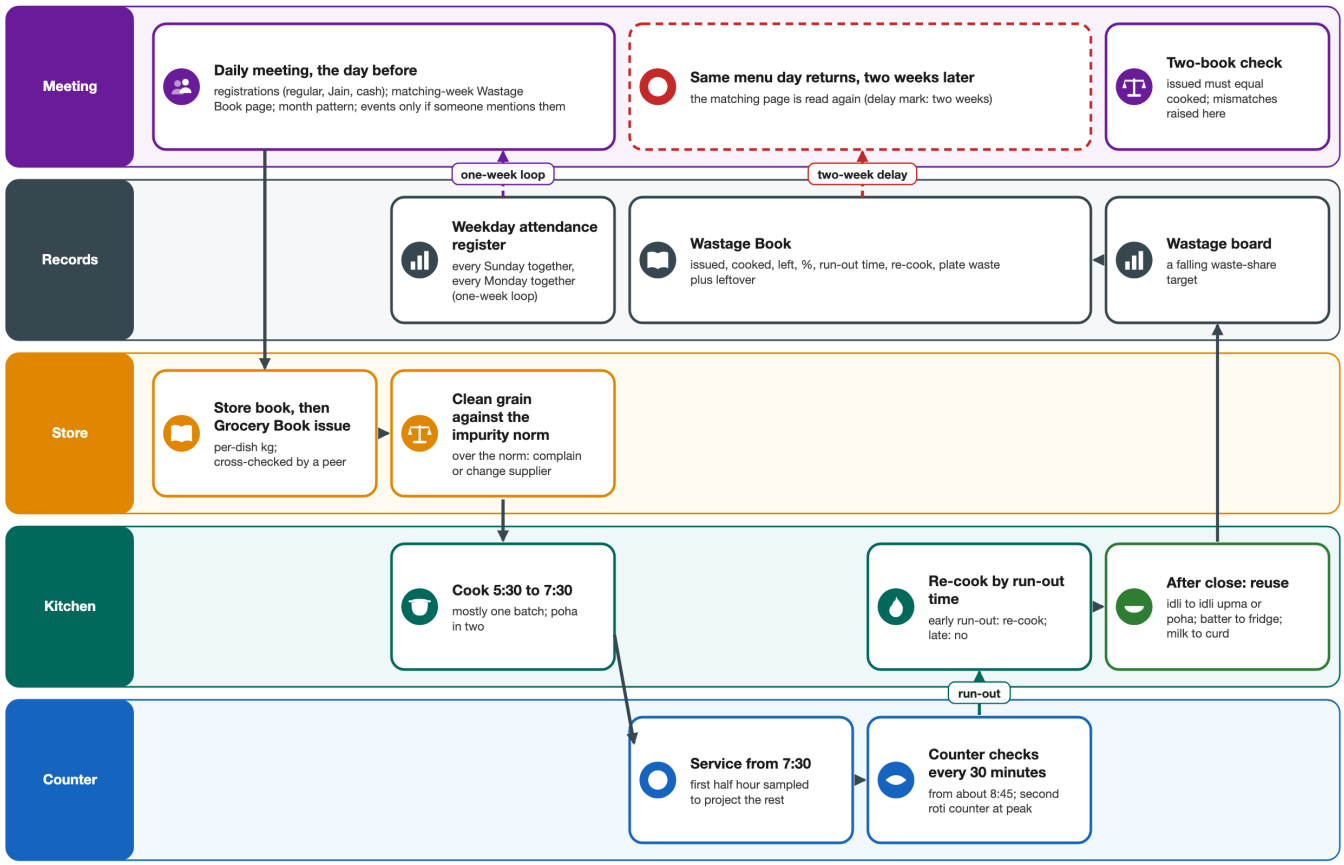


Figure 7. Yuktāhār's operator swimlane: from the daily meeting to the Wastage Book and back, with the two-week delay marked.

The breakfast day, operator side

The daily cycle diagram shows the student side. The operator side runs alongside it.

When	What happens	Confidence
One week ahead	Kadamba orders dry goods. Week by week, Bakul's manager resets each day's item-dependent share (70 to 80%)	Single-sourced
Four days ahead	Registration and cancellation close	Confirmed
Two to three days ahead	Kadamba orders some vegetables; Yuktāhār raises a vegetable indent two to three times a week and checks receipts against it	Kadamba single-sourced; Yuktāhār confirmed
Day before	Quantities set: Kadamba 70% of veg and non-veg registrations by gram standard plus about 30 outside portions; Yuktāhār from the matching-week Wastage Book page, weekday register, month's pattern and events. Kadamba orders perishables	Kadamba single-sourced; Yuktāhār confirmed
Evening before or early morning	Yuktāhār issues raw material and cleans grain against the impurity norm	Confirmed
From about 3 AM	Hafizpet starts labour-heavy Bakul items such as aloo paratha, aiming to reach Bakul about 7	Single-sourced
5:00 to 5:30	Kadamba's chef arrives at 5:30 and cooks batch items such as sambar and upma; the main veg chef leads. Yuktāhār cooking starts at 5:30 for a 7:30 finish. The early drive to Bakul takes about 20 minutes, against about 40 later (revised from an earlier 40-minute trip from a kitchen near the airport)	Single-sourced
Before the counter opens	Kadamba's food-safety sequence, in order: cooking temperature checked; a sample kept 72 hours so the food can be tested if anyone falls ill, including to tell whether the illness came from outside food; a wrapped display plate at the entrance so diners see the full menu; serving temperature per item; tasting by the facility team with two Prism staff; corrections. At Yuktāhār a tasting pair checks every shift	Display plate confirmed (observed); rest of Kadamba single-sourced; Yuktāhār confirmed

When	What happens	Confidence
7:00	Dosa and vada cooked in front of diners at Kadamba. Bakul's food arrives about 7 and its boxes go into hot-water holding, where parathas stay hot but soften in their steam	Single-sourced
About 7:30	First student scans	Confirmed
7:30 to 8:00	Yuktāhār samples this half hour to project the rest. At Kadamba it carried 15.3% of April scans	Kadamba share confirmed; Yuktāhār projection single-sourced
7:30 to 9:00	A steady, building flow; only a third of scans arrive before 8:30. At Kadamba each batch's surplus is held and reheated, and food is moved between vessels	Scans confirmed; holding and reheating is the team's judgement (candidate)
8:00 to 8:30	Bakul's manager's main rush, earlier than Kadamba's recorded curve (revised from an earlier 8:30 to 9:00 and later)	Single-sourced; no Bakul scans
Throughout service	Bakul's manager checks stock about every 30 minutes and phones Hafizpet when short	Single-sourced
About 8:45	30-minute counter checks begin at Yuktāhār; Kadamba top-ups take 10 to 15 minutes on site. A Bakul top-up's lead time is unknown: an earlier reading said up to 30 minutes, but the drive alone is 20 to 40	Confirmed at Yuktāhār; single-sourced at Kadamba; Bakul open
9:15 to 9:30	26.5% of Kadamba scans, rising to about 9 a minute by 9:29; a run-out this late likely falls past the re-cook cut-off. About 9:20 Bakul's manager aims to hold food for about 50 against 10 to 15 expected	Scans confirmed; re-cook link candidate; Bakul single-sourced
9:30	Formal cut-off. Scans continued past 9:30 on every April day, 9.2% of all scans came after it, and the last fell between 9:38 and 10:07. Latecomers use Kadamba's back door. The CFS Chair describes refills to 10:00 and lights off after	Scans confirmed; back door and refill window single-sourced
After close	Outside diners and staff eat the rest; leftovers are reused or binned; Yuktāhār records waste in the Wastage Book. At Bakul some leftovers return to Hafizpet and the rest is thrown, with no record seen	Confirmed at Yuktāhār; single-sourced at Kadamba and Bakul
Daily and weekly	Kadamba reads TDS on cooking and drinking water daily (a failure triggers a full check) and QC inspects weekly	Single-sourced
One and two weeks later	Yuktāhār's weekday register sets this day beside the same weekday a week on, and its Wastage Book page is read again when the same menu day returns	Confirmed

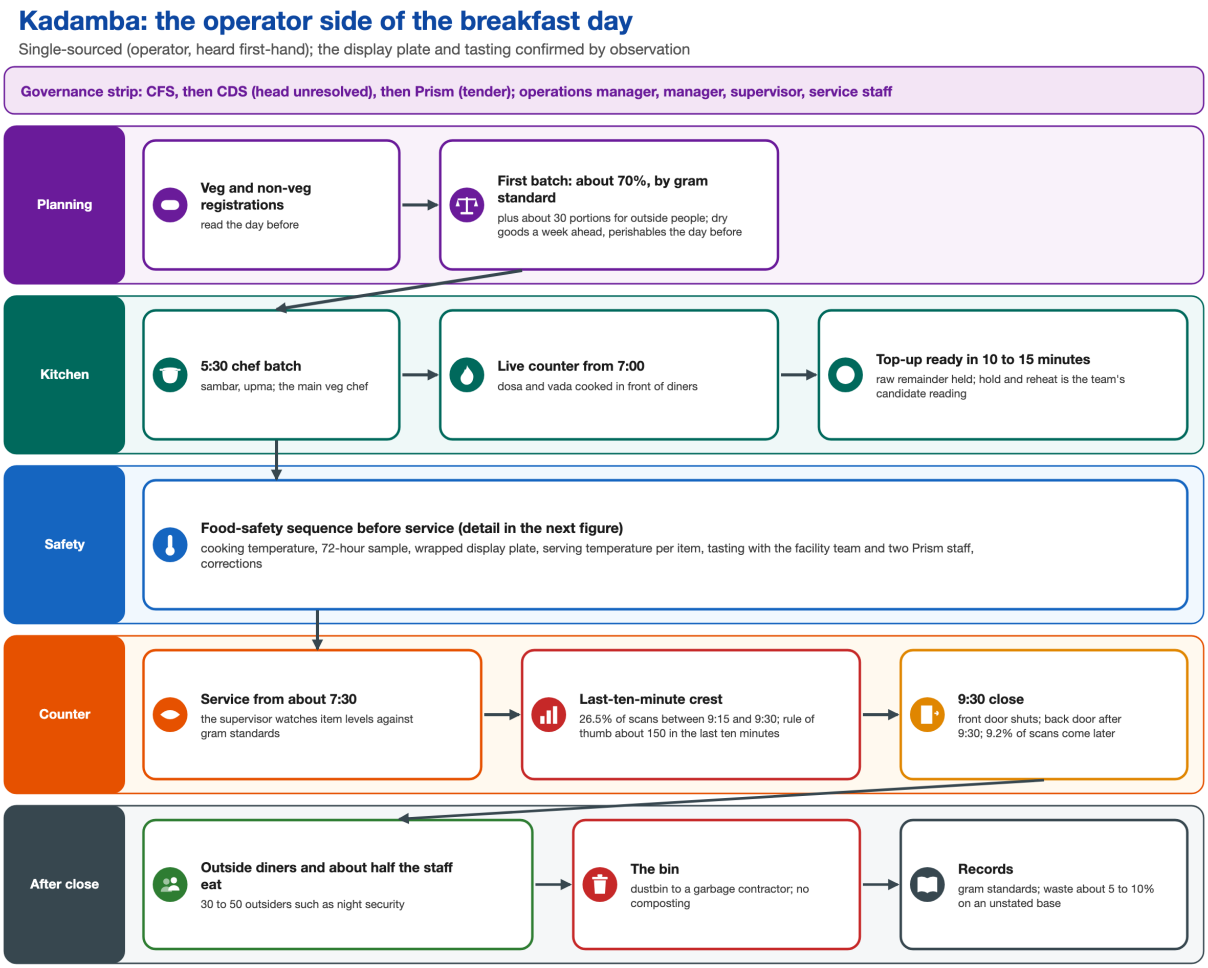


Figure 8. *Kadamba's operator swimlane: from registrations to the 9:30 close, the outside diners and the bin.*

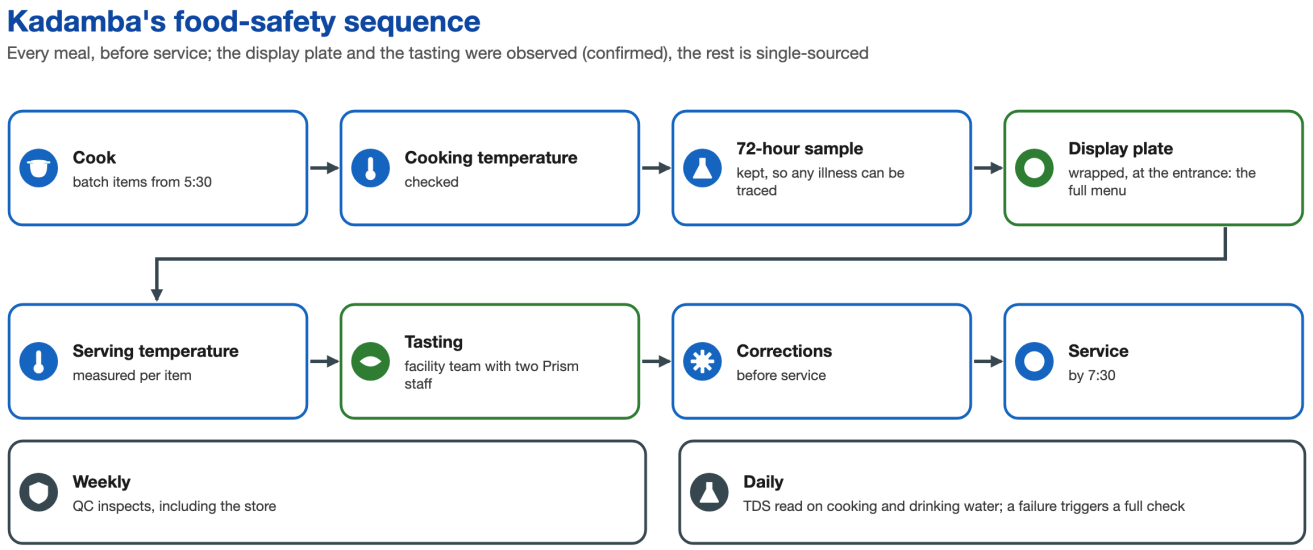


Figure 9. *The Kadamba food-safety sequence before 7:30.*

The last rows are a finding in their own right. (Revised: the first version said the best-documented correction acts only on a one-to-two-week delay.) Yuktāhār runs two corrections: a slow one, where a Thursday's breakfast shapes a later Thursday, and a fast one, where the first half hour of a meal projects the rest. The fast one samples the part of the morning least like the close. Using Kadamba's April curve as an illustration, the first half hour carries about 60 of about 398 daily scans, and projecting that rate flat across the two-hour window gives about 240, some 40% below the real total, because a quarter of diners arrive in the last quarter hour (candidate; Yuktāhār's own curve is unmeasured).

Document Formal and Informal Rules

Rules on the student side

Rule	Enforced by	Behavioural effect	Rationale known?
Registration required at least four days ahead, and automatic when a student does nothing, holidays included	CDS portal	All six respondents register in advance as a standing booking; registrations are flat across the week	Handbook: lets dining services estimate demand
Automatic vegetarian allocation for students who do not register	CDS portal	One respondent relies on it. Veg registrations at Kadamba were used at 32.4% in April against 48.5% for non-veg; whether default allocations explain part of that is a candidate	Stated in the handbook
Cancellation cap (5 per meal type per month), at least four days ahead	CDS portal	Used by most; one forgets; beyond the cap the charge cannot be avoided	Limits uncancelled no-shows
Skip Meal, no refund	CDS portal	Never used by any respondent who addressed it	Designed to reduce kitchen preparation, not billing; whether it lowers Kadamba's count is unconfirmed
Walk-in markup	CDS and operator	Used sparingly; two respondents avoid it for breakfast	Confirmed pricing incentive
Entry closes at 9:30	Mess	Four of six ask for it to be extended; at Kadamba latecomers already use the back door	Rationale unknown

Rules on the operator side

Rule	Formal or informal	Enforced by	Behavioural effect	Confidence
Paid monthly as a lump sum on plates, with deductions, under a tender	Formal (contract)	Dining services	Whether ”plates” means registered or served decides whether the operator gains or loses on every no-show; rate and deductions unverified. Kadamba describes registrations as the obligation it is paid for, Yuktāhār treats less waste as lower cost and higher profit, and Bakul's manager says payment is on plates served. That is one operator's word in tension with Kadamba's remark, and is not generalised	Single-sourced; basis unresolved
Cook a fixed share of registrations, top up live	Informal rule of thumb	Kadamba supervisor and kitchen	The stated 70% sits far above recorded turnout (37.1%). Kadamba treats cooking on registrations as a responsibility it is paid for	Ratio single-sourced; turnout confirmed; the gap candidate
Cook biryani at 100%	Informal	Kadamba	Full preparation when near-full turnout is expected; two pieces of 150 to 200 g with unlimited rice, and when some diners take three, later diners run short (lunch)	Single-sourced
Portion by per-dish gram standard	Informal but recorded	Kadamba	Standards are per person, yet the fast movers (bonda, puri, vada, idli) are the ones taken above standard	Single-sourced

Rule	Formal or informal	Enforced by	Behavioural effect	Confidence
Set an item share weekly from past attendance, never below a floor	Informal, the manager's judgement	Bakul manager	70 to 80% by item with about 70% kept on low weekends; corrects against surplus only down to the floor, and both share and floor sit above his own turnout estimate of at most about 60%	Single-sourced; written record open
Hold food for about 50 at 9:20	Informal	Bakul manager	Held rather than relying on a top-up from 8 km away; several times the 10 to 15 late arrivals he describes	Single-sourced; reason candidate
Look up the matching-week page and weekday trend, then re-project from the first half hour	Informal but documented	Yuktāhār staff in the daily meeting	The only calibrated correction seen in any mess; yet the site head believes about 50% where his register shows about 28%	Lookup confirmed; projection single-sourced
Issued must equal cooked	Informal but documented	Peers, in the daily meeting	Mismatches surface the same day; the rule covers materials, not diner counts	Single-sourced; held on the one record checked
Supplier impurity norm; re-cook only if an item runs out early; cook mostly in one batch	Informal	Yuktāhār store, daily meeting and kitchen	Impurity above the norm triggers a complaint or new supplier; late run-outs go unfilled; one batch front-loads cooked volume, and cooked food lasts only 3 to 4 hours, so surplus is recovered only by reuse	Confirmed except the norm (single-sourced)
Cook about 30 extra for outsiders; about half the staff eat at the mess	Informal, planned	Kadamba	30 to 50 outside people are fed on top of registrations and staff meals absorb surplus before it counts as waste	Single-sourced
Kadamba food-safety sequence (temperature, 72-hour sample, display plate, serving temperature, tasting, corrections); weekly QC; daily TDS	Formal (food safety)	Prism, facility team, QC	Shows the checking capacity operators already have	Display plate confirmed; rest single-sourced
Two-person tasting per shift; fridge temperature three times a day; first-in-first-out and first-expiry-first-out inventory	Formal (food safety)	Yuktāhār; Kadamba's inventory keeper; faculty visits to the store	Shows the documentation capacity operators already have	Confirmed at Yuktāhār; single-sourced at Kadamba
Blame-free waste measurement, peer cross-checking, no hierarchy	Informal norm set by management	Yuktāhār	Staff first resisted tracking (”they are catching us”) in August; managers made it blame-free and discussed it daily, and by December staff reported waste falling	Outcome confirmed; design single-sourced
Waste reduction as an explicit cost and profit goal; no formal leave policy	Informal (management)	Yuktāhār project managers and meeting	Goal: best quality, less waste, optimised workflow, lower cost, standardisation, higher profit; absences are agreed in the meeting	Single-sourced
Menu chosen by the student committee	Formal	Committee	Operators shift quantities between items but cannot drop one, and redirect menu complaints to the committee; Bakul's manager disputes pairings, not dishes	Single-sourced

Informal norms on the student side are unwritten and shared: registering for the whole month rather than day by day, which looks like the path of least resistance and which auto-registration makes the default, and one respondent's habit of checking the menu first. Going early to avoid queues is a minority behaviour, since only a third of Kadamba scans arrive before 8:30. At Yuktāhār the culture is described as family-like, and one project manager trained all staff at his farmhouse on what good quality looks like and what responsibility to take (single-sourced).

Workarounds compensate for a gap in the formal system. Mess Cell resale, used by four of six, compensates for Skip Meal's lack of refund and is mirrored on the operator side by Kadamba's manager describing students who register while away while a friend eats in their place. Eating snacks or a later meal compensates for skipping without a cost-recovery path. Early registration at Kadamba compensates for a popular mess filling up. Students enter by the back door after close. On the operator side the workarounds are a fixed ratio in place of a learned forecast at Kadamba, a weekly judgement with a shortage floor and a held reserve at Bakul, raw stock held ready for a quick top-up, holding and reheating each batch's surplus at Kadamba, leftover reuse into the next meal at Yuktāhār, and extra portions for people outside the registration.

Formal versus informal divergence

Where they diverge	Formal design	Actual behaviour
Registration as a demand signal	Registration lets dining services ”estimate demand accurately and prepare the right quantity”	Registrations are flat across the week while turnout varies. Kadamba discounts them by a fixed 70%, Bakul by an item-dependent 70 to 80% adjusted weekly but held near 70%, Yuktāhār through its records, believing about 50% where its register shows about 28%. Kadamba's ratio is not set against actual turnout, and Bakul's adjustment has no known record behind it
Registration cadence	A four-day weekly lock; the portal supports day-by-day choices	A standing monthly booking for all six respondents, made the default by automatic registration
Skip Meal	Designed to reduce kitchen preparation	Unused by any of the six. The institution's account says declarations reach the kitchen, while Kadamba says it cooks on registrations regardless; whether Skip Meal lowers the operator's count is unresolved between conflicting sources
Cancellation	The correct tool for planned non-attendance	Used inconsistently; one respondent forgets
Automatic allocation	A fallback for students who do not register	For one respondent it is their actual registration mechanism, and it applies over holidays
Closing time	Entry closes at 9:30	Scans continue past 9:30 every day, occasionally to about 10:00; refills run to 10:00; at Kadamba latecomers use the back door
Item availability at close	Designed to run until 9:30	Late run-outs are not re-cooked and staff make unkept promises to restock. At Bakul the manager holds food for about 50 at 9:20 because a Hafizpet top-up may not arrive in time (reason candidate)
Keeping off-site food hot	Insulated boxes and hot-water holding keep Bakul's food at about 60 to 72 °C	Temperature is kept, but items prepared from about 3 AM are held for hours and steam softens parathas: the chain protects heat, not texture (single-sourced)
Waste record	No waste record is part of registration and billing design	Yuktāhār keeps a detailed per-item record reconciled across its books and Kadamba reports a daily waste percentage with per-dish gram standards; no route carries either to anyone who sets registration or billing rules

Identify Negotiation and Escalation Mechanisms

(Revised: the first version said no escalation path was visible.) From the student side that still holds for rules and timing: asked whether they or anyone they know tried to change a mess rule or timing, all five new respondents said no. The operator interviews change the picture in one respect. An operational complaint path exists and works for same-incident fixes and supplier changes. The operators route it differently: Kadamba through a command chain, Yuktāhār through its daily meeting with no hierarchy.

Route	Path	Status
Operational complaints	Student, a director's email or the CDS site team, to the operator's manager, to a WhatsApp group, to the kitchen	Exists; works for same-incident fixes (single-sourced)
Kadamba command chain	CFS, CDS (head unresolved), Prism (won by tender), operations manager, manager, supervisor, service staff	Single-sourced
Yuktāhār (no hierarchy)	Staff, daily meeting and two project managers of ABC Hospitality Services, in both directions	Single-sourced
Bakul (Vijayalakshmi Caterers)	CDS team, manager, kitchen, managing director	Single-sourced, noisy audio
Upstream	Store to supplier: impurity above the norm leads to a complaint or new supplier; paneer brand switched after complaints	Single-sourced
Rule and timing changes	CDS Student Council to the CDS Committee (faculty), reached only by high-intensity feedback	Formal route on paper; unused from below
Student to rule owner	None: no respondent has used or seen a route	Absent
Operator to rule owner	None: no route for the waste record into registration or billing rules	Absent

(Revised: the first version's internal operator chain, staff to supervisor to manager to operations manager to director, came from a cut-off clip that could not be tied to one mess. The Kadamba chain above is the operator's own account, heard first-hand.) One identity in it is unresolved. The team account names one person as CDS head and the CFS Chair interview names another as CDS Chair, which may be two roles or one wrong name, and they are not merged. The ”facility team” that tastes Kadamba's food with two Prism staff is likewise unidentified and may or may not be the CDS site team.

A student complaint at Kadamba shows the boundary in action. Dinner sambar was dropped ”while they are taking more money from us,” and the operator answered that the committee decides the menu. The complaint reached the operator and stopped there, because the operator holds no menu authority.

Operators sit on the same side of the missing path as students. They have high power over quantities and none over the registration deadline, the 9:30 close, the cancellation cap or billing. At Kadamba perishables are ordered the day before and dry goods a week ahead against a lock four days out, and the operator has no channel through which to question that cut-off with anyone who sets it. The absence found in the power analysis, with feedback inputs but no outputs, is now corroborated from three sides: the governance structure, the student experience and the operators.

Track Exceptions, Workarounds and Dependencies

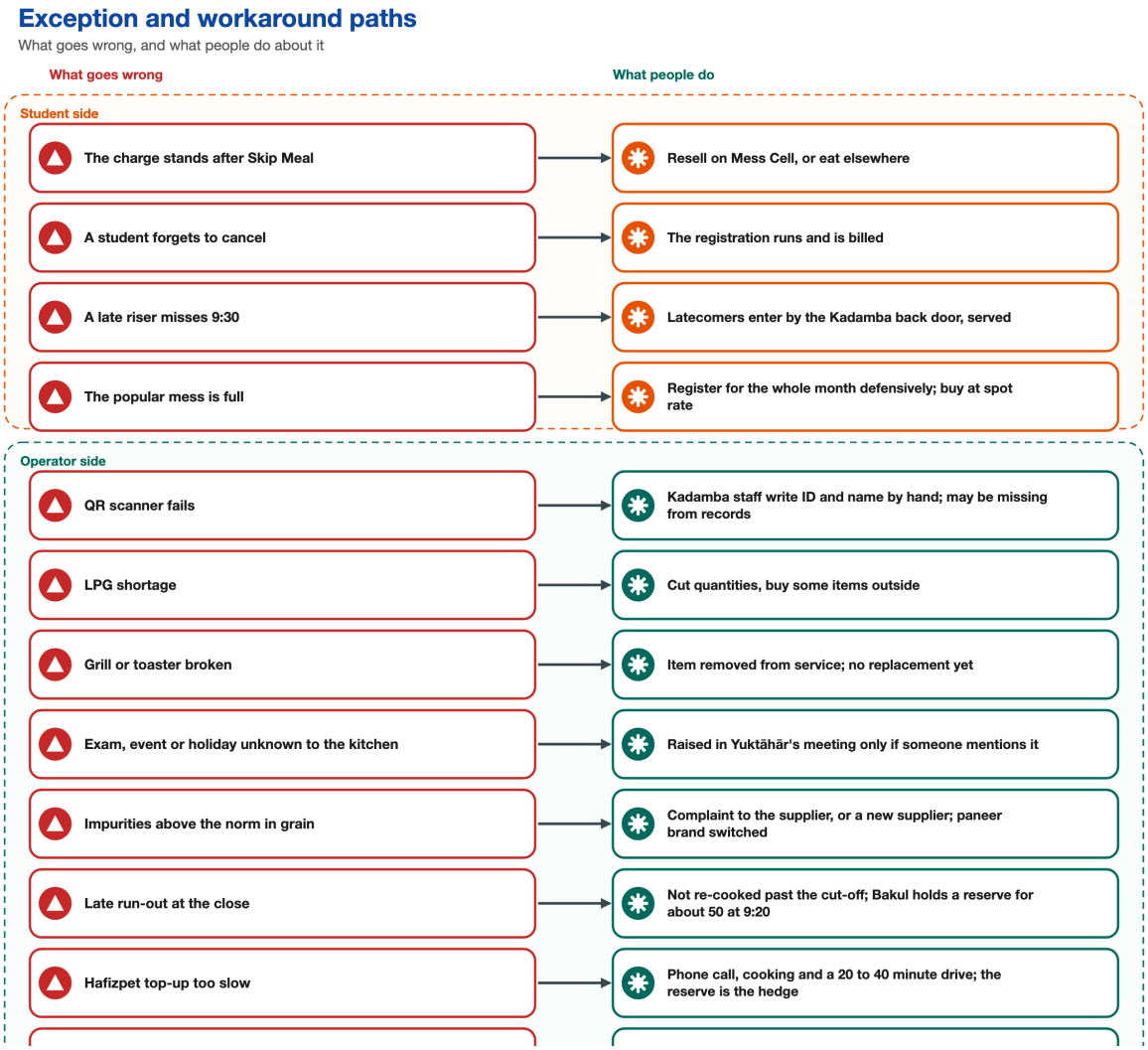


Figure 10. *Exception and workaround paths, student side and operator side.*

Operator exceptions

- **Scanner failure.** When the QR system fails, Kadamba staff write down ID and name by hand. The April export shows no sign of bulk entry (never more than two scans in one second), so hand-logged diners may be missing from the records, a candidate undercount.
- **Gas shortage.** During the LPG shortage Kadamba cut quantities a little and bought some items outside. This is the first operator account of the shortage, and its cause is still single-sourced.
- **Equipment failure.** Kadamba's bread grill is broken and unreplaced, which removes an item from service regardless of demand.
- **Events, exams and holidays.** Nothing formal tells the kitchen. They reach Yuktāhār's meeting only if someone mentions them, and hackathons and exams lower turnout in ways the site head calls unavoidable.
- **Supplier quality.** At Yuktāhār, impurities above the norm are raised in the meeting and lead to a complaint or a new supplier. Bakul's paneer has moved between three brands after complaints.
- **Biryani days.** Kadamba cooks biryani lunch at 100% rather than 70%, with a head chef brought in, so the ratio follows the operator's expectation of demand for a dish, not a fixed rule. Portion leakage (three pieces for two) still causes late run-outs at full preparation.
- **Off-site transport.** Every Bakul top-up is a phone call, a cook at Hafizpet and a 20 to 40 minute drive against a fixed close. The true lead time is unknown. The 9:20 reserve of about 50 is, as a candidate reading, the consequence: late in the window only food already held can meet late arrivals.
- **Latecomers.** When Kadamba's front door closes at 9:30, latecomers use the back door and demand food, and staff do not refuse. Last-minute registrations are called ”a pain.” The speaker's wording covers both the breakfast and dinner closes; scans after 9:30 on every April day support it at breakfast.
- **Records that disagree.** For breakfast on 3 September at Yuktāhār, the Wastage Book records 77 diners (28%) and the attendance register, on a partly obscured row, records 110 (40%). Which feeds planning is unknown. The two-book rule covers materials, not diner counts, and the two books have different keepers, which may be why the difference stands (candidate).

The operator workarounds alongside these (leftover reuse, outside diners and staff eating from the same food, holding and reheating surplus, late-door service, raw stock held for a quick top-up) are absorption mechanisms. Each soaks up part of the gap before it becomes visible, and each is locally beneficial. The outside diners and the half of Kadamba's staff who eat at the mess are real people fed by the surplus, so any change to the first batch has to plan for them. Holding and reheating is the exception among absorbers: the team judged Kadamba's food to be cooked ahead, reheated repeatedly and moved between vessels, so it degrades fast. That links over-preparation to quality as an open chain, and whether poorer quality feeds skipping is not evidenced. Bakul's hot holding carries a similar cost for a different reason: food is kept hot from an early start through transport, and steam softens parathas on the way. As a candidate reading, the food kept back for late arrivals is also the food held longest. Yuktāhār tried and dropped a commercial ERP for grocery management and rush prediction, because paying ”lakhs of rupees” for prediction made no sense when the data already sits in its books (”prediction will be based on our data only… I want to remain close to the data”), and because staff are not digitally inclined and too few people exist to digitise, so the office digitises later.

Dependencies

Eating breakfast at the mess depends on waking with enough time and alertness, the most cited constraint. It depends on the desired item still being available (run-outs confirmed by at least three of six, directly or by reputation), on no clash with class-attendance pressure (explicit for one respondent), and on the mess still being open, since the 9:30 cut-off is the most-requested change. The attendance-policy pressure depends on academic scheduling, which the governance analysis found disconnected from mess governance.

Item availability depends in turn on a chain this trace can now follow. (Revised: the first version said the Mess Office fixes each vendor's order four days out, so nothing on the day could change what is cooked.) The four-day lock applies to registration, not to cooking or buying. Yuktāhār buys groceries fortnightly by the stock register from many local shops and godowns, vegetables two to three times a week and milk daily. Kadamba buys in three tiers: dry goods a week ahead, perishables the day before, some vegetables two to three days ahead. Cooked quantity is set

the day before, and adjusted live through top-ups and re-cooks. At Bakul the first batch leaves Hafizpet before any sign of the morning's turnout, and a top-up can only add food, slowly. The binding constraint on waste is therefore cooked food prepared ahead of demand, not raw procurement: raw stock left over is issued again, while cooked food lasts only 3 to 4 hours.

The operator side has its own dependencies. They include supplier cadence and quality, and gas, electricity and water, which Yuktāhār logs daily and Kadamba checks for water quality daily. They include equipment (Kadamba's roti line, multi-item cooker and tilting curry machine, and the broken grill), and one person running all of Kadamba's inventory, a single point of failure. They include the matching-week Wastage Book page, which depends on the two-week menu rotation, and the daily meeting as the only channel for event information and exceptions at Yuktāhār. Transport from Hafizpet, about 8 km and about 20 minutes early, 40 later, bounds every Bakul top-up. Yuktāhār chooses inputs for quality (rock salt and cold-pressed oil for about six months, with visits to the mills), and staff numbers matter: Yuktāhār has 16 kitchen staff and two project managers with some site staff sharing the work, in separate tasting, cutting and cleaning teams without a hierarchy, and Kadamba about ten chefs under a main veg chef with a head chef for biryani days.

Where uneaten food finally goes is only partly settled. The CFS Chair described production and plate waste going via a garbage collector to an outside compost facility. Kadamba's manager, asked about composting, said there is none: the bin goes to the garbage contractor (single-sourced). (Revised: the first assumption that composting absorbs the physical surplus.) At Kadamba the surplus is absorbed by outside diners and staff, by holding and reheating, by latecomer top-ups and by the bin, and whether the contractor composts it off site is unverified. Yuktāhār's disposal route after reuse is not stated in any source. At Bakul some leftovers return to Hafizpet and the rest is thrown, with no onward route stated.

Key Findings

1. **The registration-attendance gap has several mechanisms, not one.** Habitual monthly over-registration made the default by automatic registration, scarcity-driven defensive registration at Kadamba, automatic allocation and simple forgetting all feed it, and the Kadamba records show their combined effect. Registration is an automatic standing booking, flat across the week while turnout varies by weekday, and not a daily demand signal.
2. **Peer influence is disconfirmed as a decision-determining factor.** Six respondents place it at most as a motivational add-on.
3. **There are three forecasting logics, not one or two.** (Revised: the first version gave every operator a private ratio, and a later one grouped Bakul with Kadamba.) Kadamba cooks a fixed 70% and tops up reactively, with no learning record beyond gram standards. Bakul varies an item-dependent 70 to 80% weekly from past attendance by the manager's judgement, never below about 70%, so its correction closes against surplus only down to that floor, and whether it rests on any written record is unknown. Yuktāhār has no fixed ratio: it learns from its books by matching week and weekday and re-projects from the first half hour, though its head believes about 50% where his register shows about 28%. None of the fixed ratios is set against actual turnout, confirmed at 37.1% for Kadamba in April. The gap is measured, locally and repeatedly, and what is missing is any route from that measurement into registration or billing rules. Even in the best-documented mess the fast correction samples the calm start of service, not the crest at the close.
4. **Broken restock promises.** Staff say an item will return before close and it does not, a trust and service finding first reported by students. The operator side offers a candidate mechanism: a re-cook cut-off that leaves late run-outs unfilled, top-ups of 10 to 15 minutes on site, an unmeasured 20 to 40 minute drive from an off-site kitchen against a close minutes away, equipment failures and items that float above their gram standard, together with a Kadamba chef's ”wait 5 minutes” that matches what students describe hearing.
5. **Under-provisioning is not the problem.** Two respondents independently said only about 30% of registrants attend and the mess still struggles to serve even that smaller group, which early drafts read as under-provisioning. The attendance half is now confirmed: about 28% at Yuktāhār in September and 37.1% at Kadamba in April, a gap of 63 to 72%. The under-provisioning reading does not hold. Every stated first-batch share sits well above that turnout, and at Bakul the share and weekend floor sit above even the manager's own estimate (candidate, no records), and Yuktāhār's book records leftovers. The shortage students feel is a timing and item-mix failure at the

close. 26.5% of Kadamba scans arrive in the last quarter hour, though the curve differs by hall, since the Bakul manager describes an earlier peak. The items students report running out (idli, puri, bhatura, fruit) include those Kadamba says float above gram standard (puri, idli), while the ones it says waste (uttapam, set dosa, upma) are left over, and late run-outs are not re-cooked. Over-preparation and run-outs happen on the same morning.

6. **The escalation-path absence is corroborated from the operator side.** An operational complaint path exists and works for same-incident fixes, but no path for changing rules or timing works for students or operators.

A tension the operator's own figures leave open. Kadamba's stated practice and stated waste do not yet add up. In April it averaged about 1,072 registrations and 398 scans a day (confirmed). A 70% first batch is about 750 portions against about 400 eaten, a surplus of about 350 a day before any top-up (candidate arithmetic from the ratio and the records). The operator reports about 5 to 10% daily wastage on no stated base (single-sourced). The two are compatible only if most of the surplus goes somewhere other than the bin: to the 30 to 50 outside diners and half the staff, to food held and reheated, to smaller top-ups than the ratio implies, or to a waste figure on a different base such as all meals or plate waste only. Which holds is not known, and this trace assumes none.

Outstanding Data Collection

Most of what this section first listed is answered. Kitchens prepare against a fixed share of registrations at Kadamba, an item-dependent weekly share with a floor at Bakul, and a matching-week lookup plus a first-half-hour projection at Yuktāhār. The Vijayalakshmi Caterers operator runs Bakul (single-sourced). Kadamba's 70% batch and the cancellation limit are heard first-hand, and so is its reporting chain. The ”30%” claim is confirmed for breakfast attendance. A candidate answer explains why particular items run out first: popularity against a fixed ratio, items floating above gram standard, and the closing surge. Unclaimed food goes to outside diners and staff, some reuse or reheating, and the bin. Operators record waste and no route carries it above them. What remains open:

- Whether a Skip Meal lowers the count Kadamba cooks against, given the earlier finding that it reaches the kitchen and the operator's statement that it cooks on registrations. One direct question settles it.
- Whether the CDS head named in the team account and the CDS Chair named earlier are two roles or one person, and who the facility team that tastes Kadamba's food is.
- What Kadamba's 5 to 10% waste figure is a percentage of (per meal or per day, cooked weight or plate waste), whether a waste record could be seen, and how the figure squares with a surplus of about 350 portions a day.
- Whether the 30 extra portions sit inside or on top of the 70% batch, how many staff ”half the staff” is, and whether staff meals are a written entitlement or a norm.
- Whether Yuktāhār uses its first-half-hour projection at breakfast and how it scales it given the closing rush; whether its two roti counters open at breakfast or only at lunch and dinner.
- Whether the mess in-charge is the person the site head's recording called by an honorific, and whether Yuktāhār's groceries are bought fortnightly (stock register), the week before use from many shops, or both.
- Confirmation that Kadamba's back-door entry happens at breakfast as well as dinner.
- The contract terms: the plate rate, how deductions work and whether costs pass through to the operator; whether Bakul is paid on plates served, as its manager says, and whether Kadamba's basis differs, confirmed from the contract or dining services.
- Where the garbage contractor takes the waste, compost or landfill; where Yuktāhār's residual waste goes; and direct observation of disposal after close.
- Whether Palash is served from the same off-site kitchen as Bakul (candidate).
- Whether Bakul's weekly adjustment rests on any written attendance, consumption or waste record by item; the lead time of a Hafizpet top-up and what happens when it is still not enough; whether the reserve of about 50 at 9:20 comes from data or judgement, and how much is left at close.
- Lunch and dinner records for Kadamba, and any records for Bakul and Palash.
- Why the Yuktāhār site head believes breakfast runs at about 50% when his register shows about 28%, and which of his two disagreeing diner records feeds planning.
- How hand-logged diners during scanner failures are reconciled into attendance records and billing.